

The fall of the Templars

In 1307, Philip IV of France had the leading members of a powerful order of warrior monks, called the Knights Templar, arrested, tortured, and burned to death. Evidence of idol worship was produced at their trial. Soon after, Pope Clement had the order broken up, and ever since their name has been surrounded by rumors of satanic occult rituals.

The Templars were founded in around 1119 by French knight Hugues de Payens to protect pilgrims journeying to the Holy Land. Their headquarters were on Temple Mount in Jerusalem, thought to be the site of King Solomon's temple. Membership of this elite fighting force was highly selective, with initiation rites so secret that revealing them was said to be punishable by death. As Europe's first bankers, the Templars were also immensely rich. Pilgrims left their valuables with them, then traveled with a proof of deposit, which they could use to withdraw funds en route.

However, the wealth and secrecy of the Knights Templar spurred resentment and suspicion. The Templars were accused of being heretics and myths grew up around them: that they spat on the cross and held dedications to the goat god Baphomet and to the Devil in the form of a black cat. Later it was speculated that they had discovered ancient occult knowledge in the Temple of Solomon, information so explosive it could bring down the Church, and even that they had possession of the Holy Grail and Shroud of Turin.

“God is not pleased.
We have enemies of the
faith in the kingdom.”

PHILIP IV, KNIGHTS' ARREST WARRANT, OCTOBER 13, 1307

